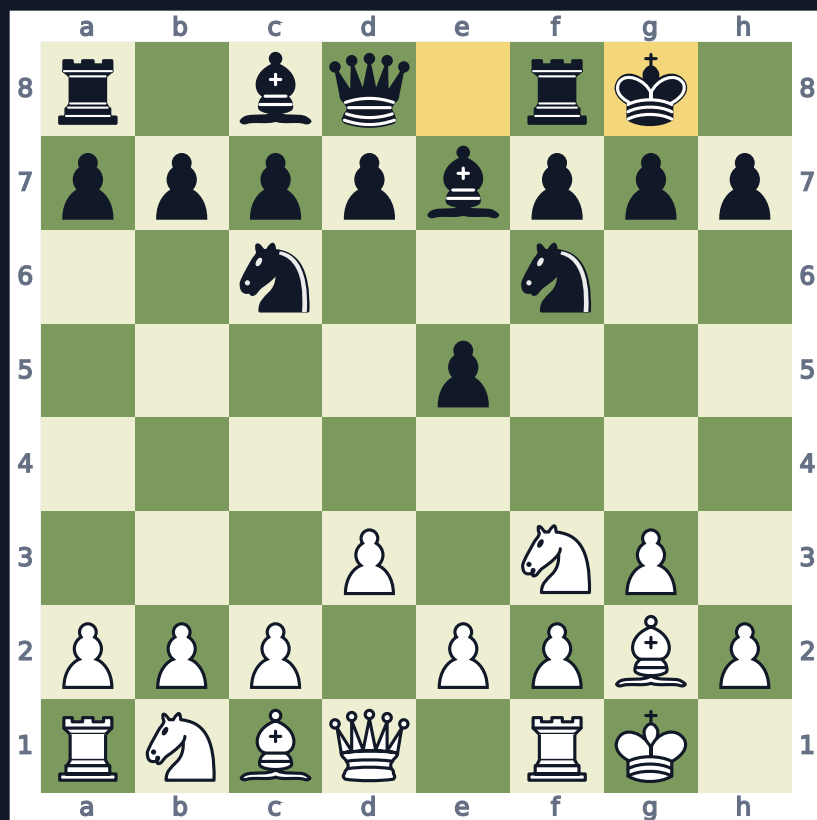


13

KIA Structures against ...e5, Caro-Kann, and Philidor

Three move orders that resemble the system but demand different central decisions.



THIS VOLUME

6

deep lessons

12

lesson positions

30

course pages

You will recognize when the KIA remains coherent and when a neighboring opening structure offers White a better version.

LEARN THE STRUCTURE, THEN THE LINE

A four-pass method for a theory-heavy opening

1. DECODE THE POSITION

Read the board before the moves. Name the center, each side's break, the worst piece, the king-safety difference, and the race clock.

2. UNDERSTAND THE CAUSAL CHAIN

Every recommendation connects a cue to a reason and a consequence. If you know only the move, you do not yet know the opening.

3. PLAY THE DECISION

Generate White's candidates, find Black's strongest reply, and choose the resulting structure you understand. The move is the end of the reasoning, not the beginning.

4. RETRIEVE UNDER PRESSURE

Cover the answer key, reconstruct the line, and speak the memory rule. Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days, then test the idea in a slow game.

THEORY WARNING

This is a durable concept-first repertoire, not a claim to be a live engine database. Before tournament use, verify sharp forcing branches in Fritz or a current database.

Priority order at the board: legality and tactical survival, king safety, forcing moves, central transformation, activity, structure, then the remembered rule.

SIX LINKED LESSONS

Recognition first, execution second

LESSON 073 | PAGE 4

Decode: The ...e5 classical center*Against ...e5, play the position as a reversed king-pawn opening and create a break.*

LESSON 074 | PAGE 8

Play: The ...e5 classical center*Against ...e5, play the position as a reversed king-pawn opening and create a break.*

LESSON 075 | PAGE 12

Decode: The Caro-Kann KIA route*Against the Caro center, challenge the pawns first; attack only after the structure changes.*

LESSON 076 | PAGE 16

Play: The Caro-Kann KIA route*Against the Caro center, challenge the pawns first; attack only after the structure changes.*

LESSON 077 | PAGE 20

Decode: The Philidor-like shell*A compact black center should be challenged before it completes its freeing break.*

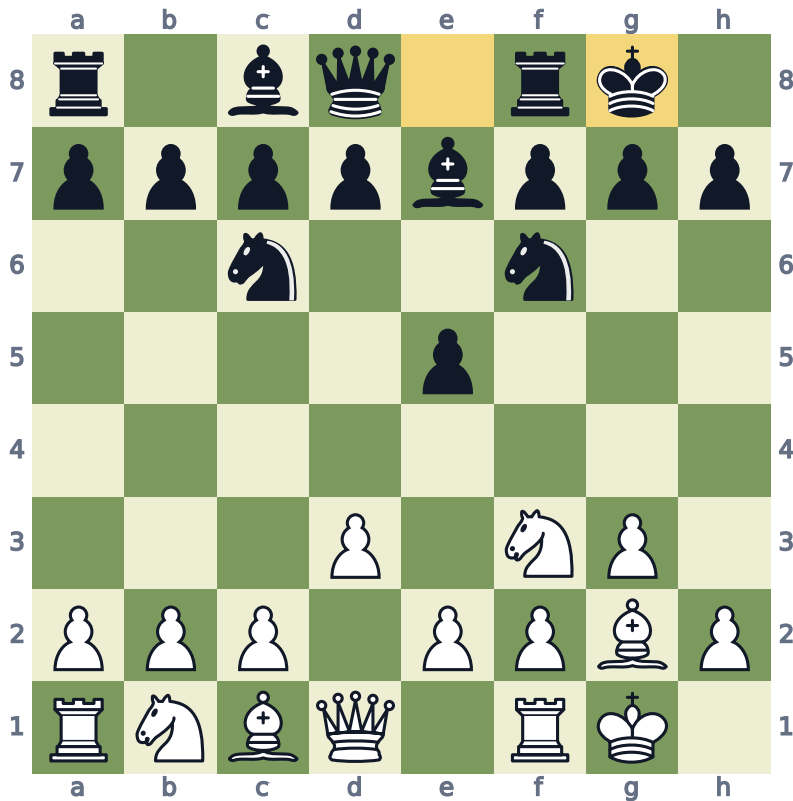
LESSON 078 | PAGE 24

Play: The Philidor-like shell*A compact black center should be challenged before it completes its freeing break.***VOLUME OBJECTIVE**

You will recognize when the KIA remains coherent and when a neighboring opening structure offers White a better version.

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: The ...e5 classical center



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Against ...e5, White reaches a reversed closed king-pawn structure where d4 and f4, not e5, are the critical breaks.

DECISION RULE

Which break opens a useful line for the g2 bishop and preserves king safety?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black prepares ...Bf8, ...d5, or queenside activity and uses the equal center to neutralize slow maneuvers.

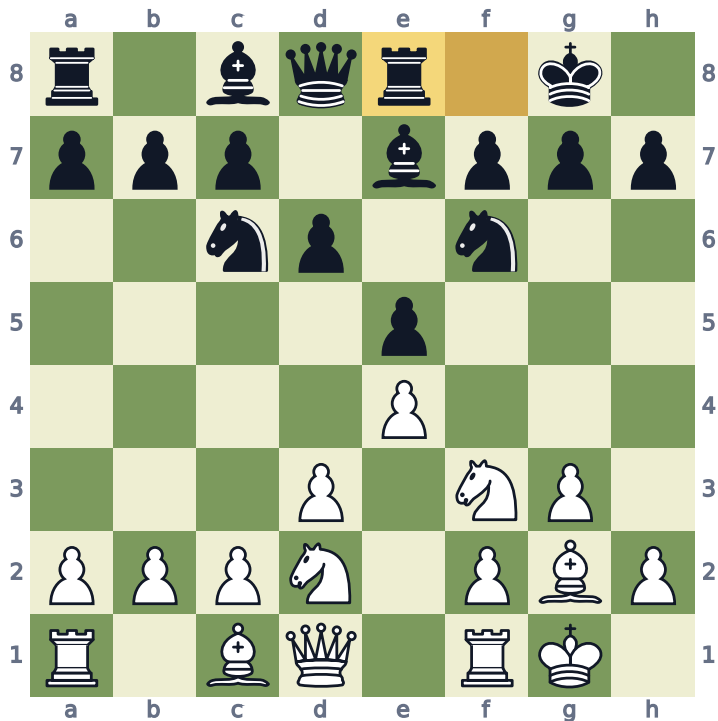
WHITE'S PLAN

White uses Re1, c3, and a timed d4 or f4 to exploit the extra tempo without overextending.

MEMORY RULE | Against ...e5, play the position as a reversed king-pawn opening and create a break.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Against ...e5, White reaches a reversed closed king-pawn structure where d4 and f4, not e5, are the critical breaks.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Black prepares ...Bf8, ...d5, or queenside activity and uses the equal center to neutralize slow maneuvers.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White uses Re1, c3, and a timed d4 or f4 to exploit the extra tempo without overextending.

FAILURE MODE

Calling the position a KIA and forcing an e5 advance into Black's occupied square.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Which break opens a useful line for the g2 bishop and preserves king safety? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

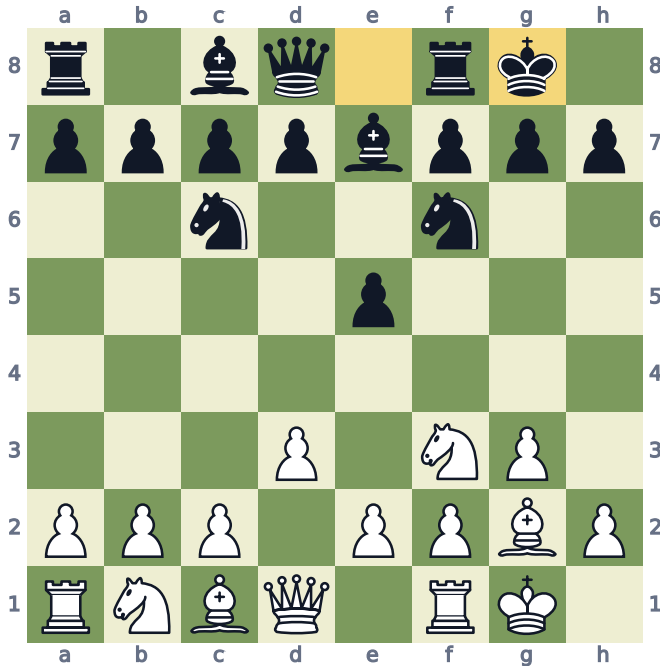
RULE | Against ...e5, play the position as a reversed king-pawn opening and create a break.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. Nf3 Nc6 2. g3 e5 3. Bg2 Nf6 4. O-O Be7 5. d3 O-O 6. Nbd2 d6 7. e4 Re8



- Bg2: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the pawn break that will make the diagonal useful.
- Nf6: Black reroutes a knight to f6; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- O-O: White secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
- Be7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the pawn break that will make the diagonal useful.
- d3: White supports e4 and keeps the center compact at the cost of space on d4.
- O-O: Black secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Against ...e5, White reaches a reversed closed king-pawn structure where d4 and f4, not e5, are the critical breaks.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Which break opens a useful line for the g2 bishop and preserves king safety? White's attacking or positional plan is: White uses Re1, c3, and a timed d4 or f4 to exploit the extra tempo without overextending. The line fails as a template when: Calling the position a KIA and forcing an e5 advance into Black's occupied square.

STORE THIS | Against ...e5, play the position as a reversed king-pawn opening and create a break.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's most urgent counterplay, and which pawn break enables it?

3. What is White's primary plan, and which piece or pawn makes it work?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

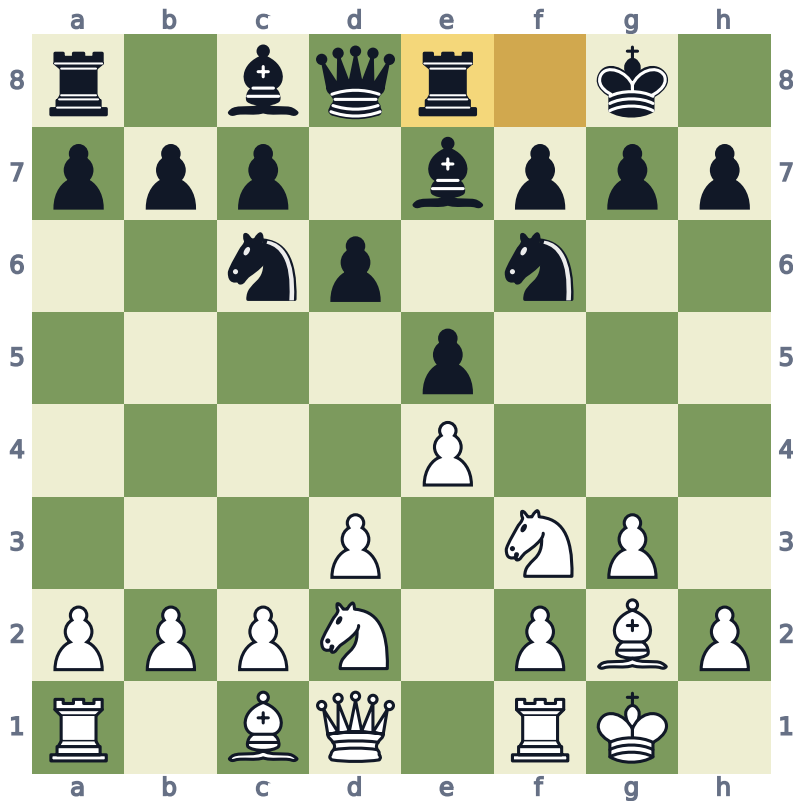
1. Against ...e5, White reaches a reversed closed king-pawn structure where d4 and f4, not e5, are the critical breaks. 2. Black prepares ...Bf8, ...d5, or queenside activity and uses the equal center to neutralize slow maneuvers. 3. White uses Re1, c3, and a timed d4 or f4 to exploit the extra tempo without overextending. 4. Which break opens a useful line for the g2 bishop and preserves king safety? 5. Calling the position a KIA and forcing an e5 advance into Black's occupied square.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 10 plies from memory, then replay: 3. Bg2 Nf6 4. O-O Be7 5. d3 O-O

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: The ...e5 classical center



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Against ...e5, White reaches a reversed closed king-pawn structure where d4 and f4, not e5, are the critical breaks.

DECISION RULE

Which break opens a useful line for the g2 bishop and preserves king safety?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black prepares ...Bf8, ...d5, or queenside activity and uses the equal center to neutralize slow maneuvers.

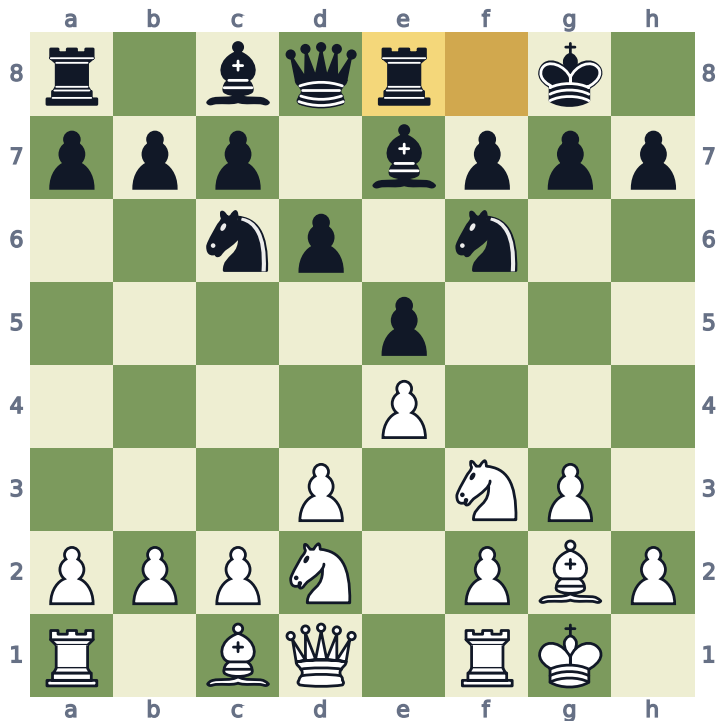
WHITE'S PLAN

White uses Re1, c3, and a timed d4 or f4 to exploit the extra tempo without overextending.

MEMORY RULE | Against ...e5, play the position as a reversed king-pawn opening and create a break.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Against ...e5, White reaches a reversed closed king-pawn structure where d4 and f4, not e5, are the critical breaks.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Black prepares ...Bf8, ...d5, or queenside activity and uses the equal center to neutralize slow maneuvers.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White uses Re1, c3, and a timed d4 or f4 to exploit the extra tempo without overextending.

FAILURE MODE

Calling the position a KIA and forcing an e5 advance into Black's occupied square.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Which break opens a useful line for the g2 bishop and preserves king safety? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

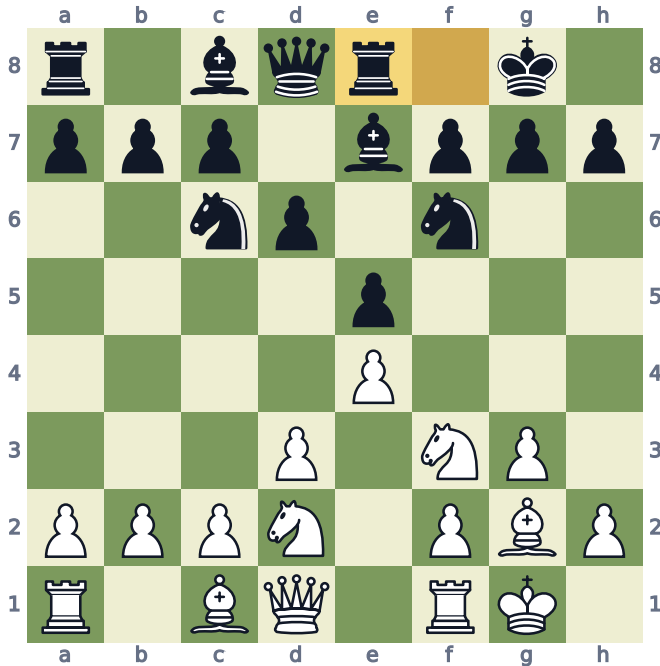
RULE | Against ...e5, play the position as a reversed king-pawn opening and create a break.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. Nf3 Nc6 2. g3 e5 3. Bg2 Nf6 4. O-O Be7 5. d3 O-O 6. Nbd2 d6 7. e4 Re8



- d3: White supports e4 and keeps the center compact at the cost of space on d4.
- O-O: Black secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
- Nbd2: White reroutes a knight to d2; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- d6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.
- e4: White builds the KIA center but must account for Black's immediate central break.
- Re8: Black places a rook behind a pawn break or file expected to open.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Against ...e5, White reaches a reversed closed king-pawn structure where d4 and f4, not e5, are the critical breaks.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Which break opens a useful line for the g2 bishop and preserves king safety? White's attacking or positional plan is: White uses Re1, c3, and a timed d4 or f4 to exploit the extra tempo without overextending. The line fails as a template when: Calling the position a KIA and forcing an e5 advance into Black's occupied square.

STORE THIS | Against ...e5, play the position as a reversed king-pawn opening and create a break.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's most urgent counterplay, and which pawn break enables it?

3. What is White's primary plan, and which piece or pawn makes it work?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

1. Against ...e5, White reaches a reversed closed king-pawn structure where d4 and f4, not e5, are the critical breaks. 2. Black prepares ...Bf8, ...d5, or queenside activity and uses the equal center to neutralize slow maneuvers. 3. White uses Re1, c3, and a timed d4 or f4 to exploit the extra tempo without overextending. 4. Which break opens a useful line for the g2 bishop and preserves king safety? 5. Calling the position a KIA and forcing an e5 advance into Black's occupied square.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 14 plies from memory, then replay: 5. d3 O-O 6. Nbd2 d6 7. e4 Re8

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: The Caro-Kann KIA route



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

The Caro move order gives Black a broad e5-d5 center; White's d3 setup is sound but must challenge the center before it becomes effortless space.

DECISION RULE

Can White undermine e5 with d4, and which exchange leaves the better minor pieces?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black supports the center, develops behind it, and prepares ...Nbd7 or ...a5 while White remains compact.

WHITE'S PLAN

White uses Re1, c3, and d4 or an e5 pressure plan rather than assuming a French-style locked chain.

MEMORY RULE | Against the Caro center, challenge the pawns first; attack only after the structure changes.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

The Caro move order gives Black a broad e5-d5 center; White's d3 setup is sound but must challenge the center before it becomes effortless space.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Black supports the center, develops behind it, and prepares ...Nbd7 or ...a5 while White remains compact.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White uses Re1, c3, and d4 or an e5 pressure plan rather than assuming a French-style locked chain.

FAILURE MODE

Playing h4 and Nf1 while Black owns the full center and no pawn chain points toward the king.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Can White undermine e5 with d4, and which exchange leaves the better minor pieces? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

RULE | Against the Caro center, challenge the pawns first; attack only after the structure changes.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c6 2. d3 d5 3. Nd2 e5 4. Ngf3 Bd6 5. g3 Nf6 6. Bg2 O-O 7. O-O Re8



- Nd2: White reroutes a knight to d2; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- e5: Black builds a symmetrical center that requires White to create a new pawn break.
- Ngf3: White reroutes a knight to f3; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- Bd6: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the pawn break that will make the diagonal useful.
- g3: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.
- Nf6: Black reroutes a knight to f6; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

The Caro move order gives Black a broad e5-d5 center; White's d3 setup is sound but must challenge the center before it becomes effortless space.

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STORE THIS | Against the Caro center, challenge the pawns first; attack only after the structure changes.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

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3. What is White's primary plan, and which piece or pawn makes it work?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

1. The Caro move order gives Black a broad e5-d5 center; White's d3 setup is sound but must challenge the center before it becomes effortless space. 2. Black supports the center, develops behind it, and prepares ...Nbd7 or ...a5 while White remains compact. 3. White uses Re1, c3, and d4 or an e5 pressure plan rather than assuming a French-style locked chain. 4. Can White undermine e5 with d4, and which exchange leaves the better minor pieces? 5. Playing h4 and Nf1 while Black owns the full center and no pawn chain points toward the king.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 10 plies from memory, then replay: 3. Nd2 e5 4. Ngf3 Bd6 5. g3 Nf6

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: The Caro-Kann KIA route



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

The Caro move order gives Black a broad e5-d5 center; White's d3 setup is sound but must challenge the center before it becomes effortless space.

DECISION RULE

Can White undermine e5 with d4, and which exchange leaves the better minor pieces?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black supports the center, develops behind it, and prepares ...Nbd7 or ...a5 while White remains compact.

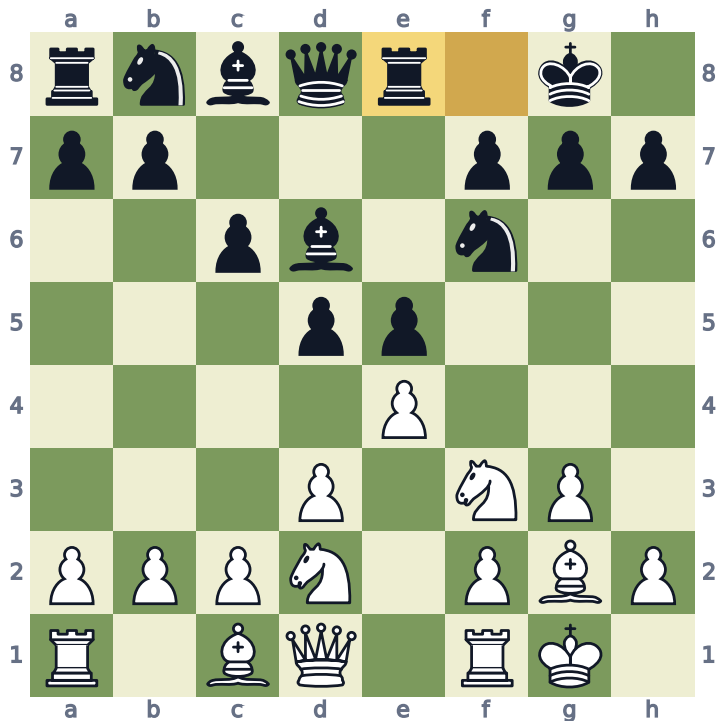
WHITE'S PLAN

White uses Re1, c3, and d4 or an e5 pressure plan rather than assuming a French-style locked chain.

MEMORY RULE | Against the Caro center, challenge the pawns first; attack only after the structure changes.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

The Caro move order gives Black a broad e5-d5 center; White's d3 setup is sound but must challenge the center before it becomes effortless space.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Black supports the center, develops behind it, and prepares ...Nbd7 or ...a5 while White remains compact.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White uses Re1, c3, and d4 or an e5 pressure plan rather than assuming a French-style locked chain.

FAILURE MODE

Playing h4 and Nf1 while Black owns the full center and no pawn chain points toward the king.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Can White undermine e5 with d4, and which exchange leaves the better minor pieces? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

RULE | Against the Caro center, challenge the pawns first; attack only after the structure changes.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c6 2. d3 d5 3. Nd2 e5 4. Ngf3 Bd6 5. g3 Nf6 6. Bg2 O-O 7. O-O Re8



- g3: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.
- Nf6: Black reroutes a knight to f6; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- Bg2: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the pawn break that will make the diagonal useful.
- O-O: Black secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
- O-O: White secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
- Re8: Black places a rook behind a pawn break or file expected to open.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

The Caro move order gives Black a broad e5-d5 center; White's d3 setup is sound but must challenge the center before it becomes effortless space.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Can White undermine e5 with d4, and which exchange leaves the better minor pieces? White's attacking or positional plan is: White uses Re1, c3, and d4 or an e5 pressure plan rather than assuming a French-style locked chain. The line fails as a template when: Playing h4 and Nf1 while Black owns the full center and no pawn chain points toward the king.

STORE THIS | Against the Caro center, challenge the pawns first; attack only after the structure changes.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's most urgent counterplay, and which pawn break enables it?

3. What is White's primary plan, and which piece or pawn makes it work?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

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ANSWER KEY

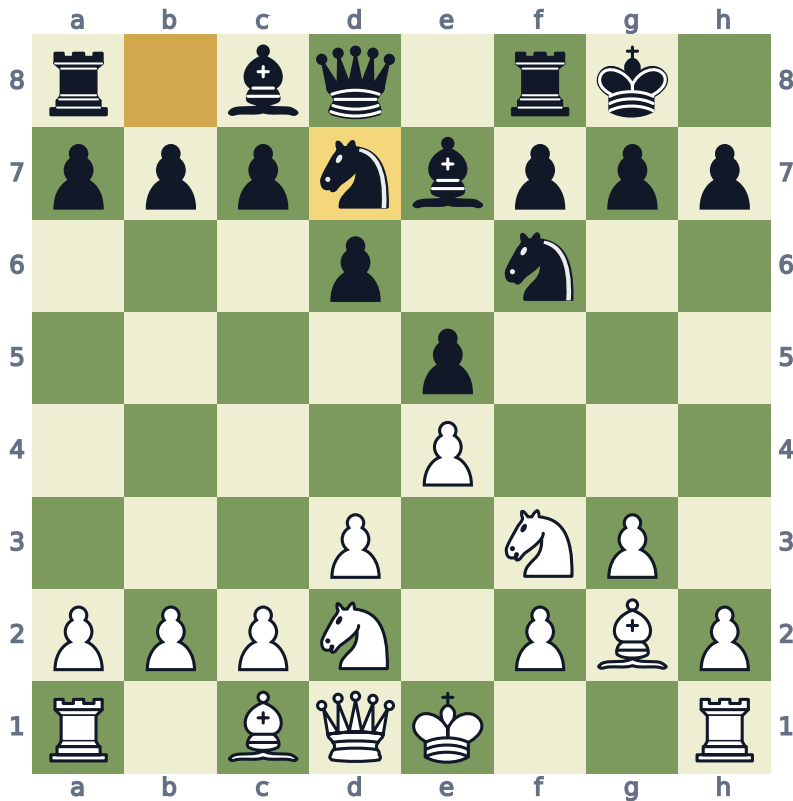
1. The Caro move order gives Black a broad e5-d5 center; White's d3 setup is sound but must challenge the center before it becomes effortless space. 2. Black supports the center, develops behind it, and prepares ...Nbd7 or ...a5 while White remains compact. 3. White uses Re1, c3, and d4 or an e5 pressure plan rather than assuming a French-style locked chain. 4. Can White undermine e5 with d4, and which exchange leaves the better minor pieces? 5. Playing h4 and Nf1 while Black owns the full center and no pawn chain points toward the king.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 14 plies from memory, then replay: 5. g3 Nf6 6. Bg2 O-O 7. O-O Re8

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: The Philidor-like shell



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Black's d6-e5 shell is solid but slightly cramped; White can build slowly, yet must decide whether d4 or c3-d4 is the true source of advantage.

DECISION RULE

Can White play d4 directly, and what black recapture or break follows?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black seeks ...Re8, ...Bf8, and ...d5, using the restrained structure to remove White's first-move pressure.

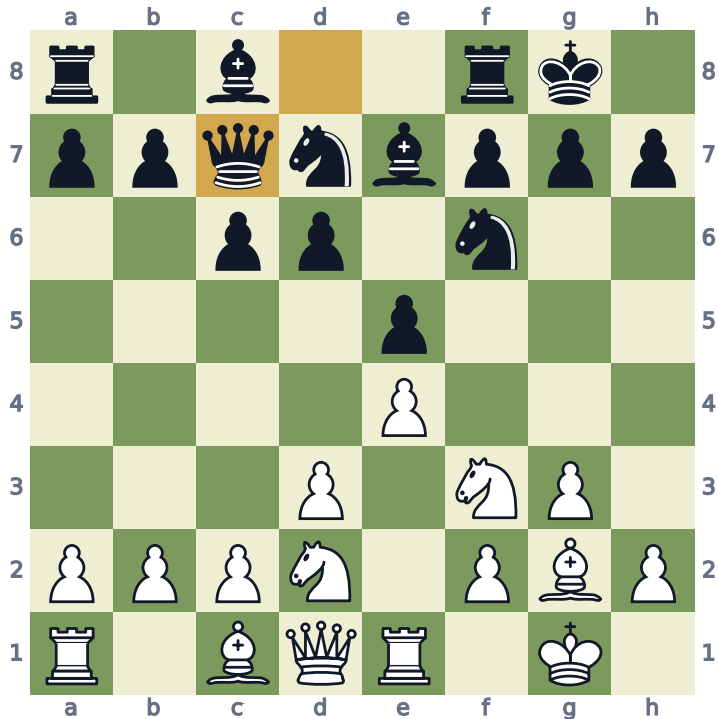
WHITE'S PLAN

White improves pieces, controls d4, and opens the center when the g2 bishop and rooks benefit.

MEMORY RULE | A compact black center should be challenged before it completes its freeing break.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White improves pieces, controls d4, and opens the center when the g2 bishop and rooks benefit.

CUE

Black's d6-e5 shell is solid but slightly cramped; White can build slowly, yet must decide whether d4 or c3-d4 is the true source of advantage.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Black seeks ...Re8, ...Bf8, and ...d5, using the restrained structure to remove White's first-move pressure.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

FAILURE MODE

Maneuvering indefinitely because the structure looks familiar while Black achieves ...d5 for free.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Can White play d4 directly, and what black recapture or break follows? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

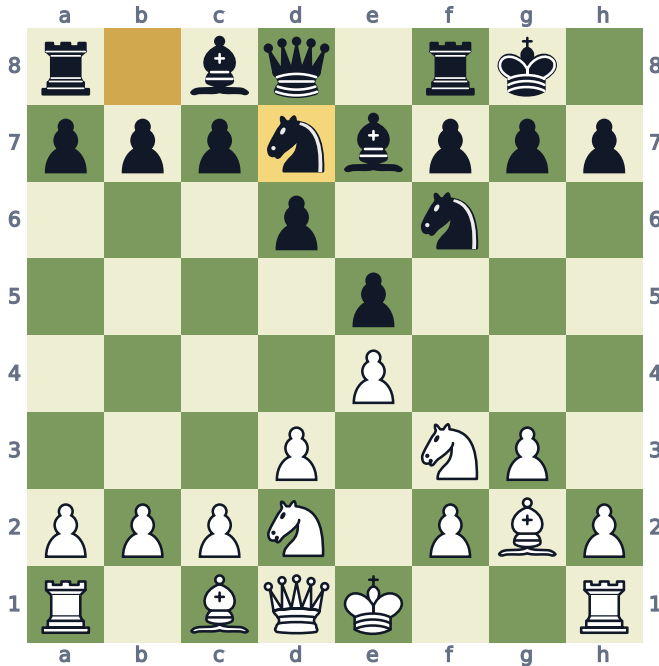
RULE | A compact black center should be challenged before it completes its freeing break.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 d6 2. d3 Nf6 3. Nd2 e5 4. Ngf3 Be7 5. g3 O-O 6. Bg2 Nbd7 7. O-O c6 8. Re1 Qc7



- Ngf3: White reroutes a knight to f3; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- Be7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the pawn break that will make the diagonal useful.
- g3: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.
- O-O: Black secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
- Bg2: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the pawn break that will make the diagonal useful.
- Nbd7: Black reroutes a knight to d7; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Black's d6-e5 shell is solid but slightly cramped; White can build slowly, yet must decide whether d4 or c3-d4 is the true source of advantage.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Can White play d4 directly, and what black recapture or break follows? White's attacking or positional plan is: White improves pieces, controls d4, and opens the center when the g2 bishop and rooks benefit. The line fails as a template when: Maneuvering indefinitely because the structure looks familiar while Black achieves ...d5 for free.

STORE THIS | A compact black center should be challenged before it completes its freeing break.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's most urgent counterplay, and which pawn break enables it?

3. What is White's primary plan, and which piece or pawn makes it work?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

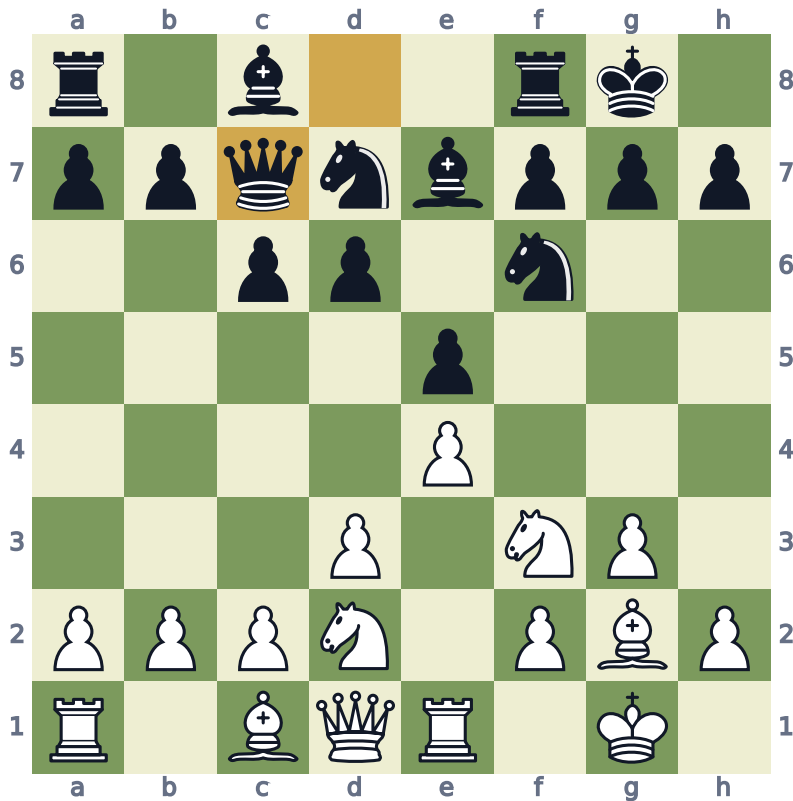
1. Black's d6-e5 shell is solid but slightly cramped; White can build slowly, yet must decide whether d4 or c3-d4 is the true source of advantage. 2. Black seeks ...Re8, ...Bf8, and ...d5, using the restrained structure to remove White's first-move pressure. 3. White improves pieces, controls d4, and opens the center when the g2 bishop and rooks benefit. 4. Can White play d4 directly, and what black recapture or break follows? 5. Maneuvering indefinitely because the structure looks familiar while Black achieves ...d5 for free.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. Ngf3 Be7 5. g3 O-O 6. Bg2 Nbd7

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: The Philidor-like shell



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Black's d6-e5 shell is solid but slightly cramped; White can build slowly, yet must decide whether d4 or c3-d4 is the true source of advantage.

DECISION RULE

Can White play d4 directly, and what black recapture or break follows?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black seeks ...Re8, ...Bf8, and ...d5, using the restrained structure to remove White's first-move pressure.

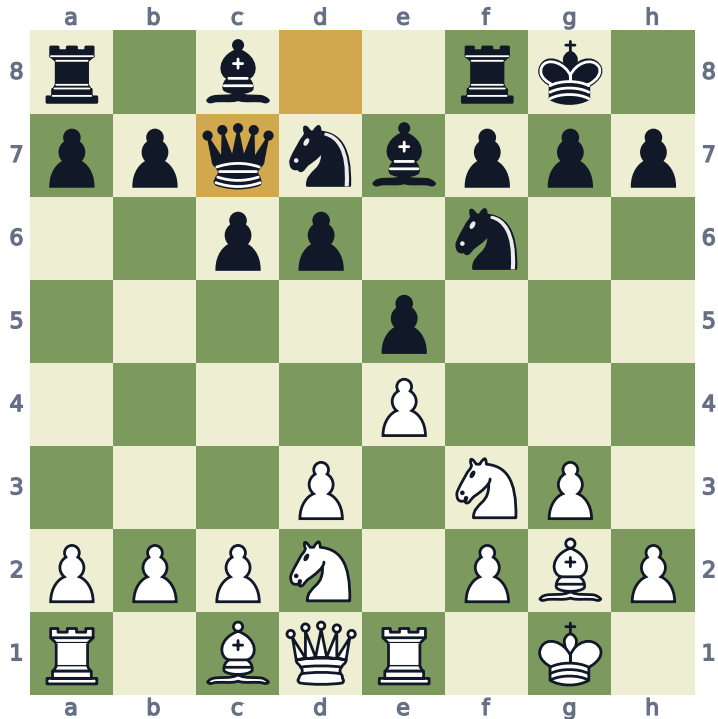
WHITE'S PLAN

White improves pieces, controls d4, and opens the center when the g2 bishop and rooks benefit.

MEMORY RULE | A compact black center should be challenged before it completes its freeing break.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Black's d6-e5 shell is solid but slightly cramped; White can build slowly, yet must decide whether d4 or c3-d4 is the true source of advantage.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Black seeks ...Re8, ...Bf8, and ...d5, using the restrained structure to remove White's first-move pressure.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White improves pieces, controls d4, and opens the center when the g2 bishop and rooks benefit.

FAILURE MODE

Maneuvering indefinitely because the structure looks familiar while Black achieves ...d5 for free.

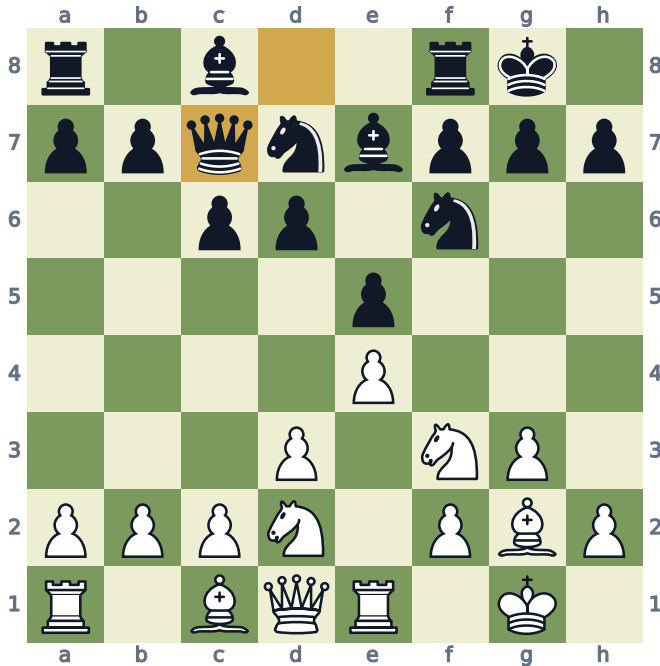
DECISION TEST

Ask: Can White play d4 directly, and what black recapture or break follows? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

RULE | A compact black center should be challenged before it completes its freeing break.

Move-by-move meaning

1. e4 d6 2. d3 Nf6 3. Nd2 e5 4. Ngf3 Be7 5. g3 O-O 6. Bg2 Nbd7 7. O-O c6 8. Re1 Qc7



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COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's most urgent counterplay, and which pawn break enables it?

3. What is White's primary plan, and which piece or pawn makes it work?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

1. Black's d6-e5 shell is solid but slightly cramped; White can build slowly, yet must decide whether d4 or c3-d4 is the true source of advantage. 2. Black seeks ...Re8, ...Bf8, and ...d5, using the restrained structure to remove White's first-move pressure. 3. White improves pieces, controls d4, and opens the center when the g2 bishop and rooks benefit. 4. Can White play d4 directly, and what black recapture or break follows? 5. Maneuvering indefinitely because the structure looks familiar while Black achieves ...d5 for free.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. Bg2 Nbd7 7. O-O c6 8. Re1 Qc7

SIX-POSITION TEST

Can you retrieve the plan without the chapter?

LESSON 073 Decode: The ...e5 classical center

Prompt: Which break opens a useful line for the g2 bishop and preserves king safety?

Recall: Against ...e5, play the position as a reversed king-pawn opening and create a break.

LESSON 074 Play: The ...e5 classical center

Prompt: Which break opens a useful line for the g2 bishop and preserves king safety?

Recall: Against ...e5, play the position as a reversed king-pawn opening and create a break.

LESSON 075 Decode: The Caro-Kann KIA route

Prompt: Can White undermine e5 with d4, and which exchange leaves the better minor pieces?

Recall: Against the Caro center, challenge the pawns first; attack only after the structure changes.

LESSON 076 Play: The Caro-Kann KIA route

Prompt: Can White undermine e5 with d4, and which exchange leaves the better minor pieces?

Recall: Against the Caro center, challenge the pawns first; attack only after the structure changes.

LESSON 077 Decode: The Philidor-like shell

Prompt: Can White play d4 directly, and what black recapture or break follows?

Recall: A compact black center should be challenged before it completes its freeing break.

LESSON 078 Play: The Philidor-like shell

Prompt: Can White play d4 directly, and what black recapture or break follows?

Recall: A compact black center should be challenged before it completes its freeing break.

PASS STANDARD

For each position: name the structure, Black's counterplay, White's plan, one candidate, the strongest reply, and the failure mode. Score one point each; 30 of 36 is a pass.

THREE SCENARIOS TO STORE

One-page repertoire memory sheet

CARD 1

The ...e5 classical center

1. Nf3 Nc6 2. g3 e5 3. Bg2 Nf6 4. O-O Be7 5. d3 O-O 6. Nbd2 d6 7. e4 Re8

Decision: Which break opens a useful line for the g2 bishop and preserves king safety?

Memory: Against ...e5, play the position as a reversed king-pawn opening and create a break.

CARD 2

The Caro-Kann KIA route

1. e4 c6 2. d3 d5 3. Nd2 e5 4. Ngf3 Bd6 5. g3 Nf6 6. Bg2 O-O 7. O-O Re8

Decision: Can White undermine e5 with d4, and which exchange leaves the better minor pieces?

Memory: Against the Caro center, challenge the pawns first; attack only after the structure changes.

CARD 3

The Philidor-like shell

1. e4 d6 2. d3 Nf6 3. Nd2 e5 4. Ngf3 Be7 5. g3 O-O 6. Bg2 Nbd7 7. O-O c6 8. Re1 Qc7

Decision: Can White play d4 directly, and what black recapture or break follows?

Memory: A compact black center should be challenged before it completes its freeing break.

Reconstruct each card from the final position, then from the opening moves alone.

SPACED RETRIEVAL AND GAME TRANSFER

Volume mastery tracker

Lesson	D1	D3	D7	D14	D30	Game	Pass
073 Decode: The ...e5 classical center	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
074 Play: The ...e5 classical center	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
075 Decode: The Caro-Kann KIA route	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
076 Play: The Caro-Kann KIA route	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
077 Decode: The Philidor-like shell	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
078 Play: The Philidor-like shell	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

TWELVE-WEEK CYCLE

Weeks 1-2: decode the three structures. Weeks 3-4: replay all lines from memory. Weeks 5-7: solve the workbook pages. Weeks 8-10: test in slow games or against Fritz. Weeks 11-12: analyze failures and retest the volume examination.

PROMOTION RULE

Advance only when you can explain every memory rule, reproduce the three reference lines, name Black's strongest counterplay, and show at least one analyzed game where the decision appeared.

Do not measure mastery by pages completed. Measure whether the correct questions appear during a real game.